Comprehensive Research Report: Methodologies and Frameworks for Discovering and Operationalizing Cultural Values in a Catholic Parish

Introduction to Organizational Culture in a Faith-Based Context

The endeavor to uncover, codify, and operationalize the cultural values of an organization represents a critical juncture in strategic management, particularly within non-profit and faith-based institutions such as a Catholic parish. Historically, ecclesiastical bodies have relied almost exclusively on theological doctrine, canon law, and diocesan mandates to define their identity. However, modern parish administration increasingly recognizes that a church functions as a complex socio-organizational system. In this context, the culture of the parish dictates how theological concepts are practically lived, how decisions are made, how resources are allocated, and how parishioners experience the community.

Organizational culture is the invisible architecture of a community. It encompasses the shared beliefs, unspoken norms, and collective behaviors that dictate the daily reality of the institution. For a parish Research and Development (R&D) unit working in tandem with a Cadre Formation team, defining this culture is not merely an exercise in corporate branding; it is a vital diagnostic process that aligns the lived reality of the congregation with its espoused spiritual mission. The Cadre Formation team cannot effectively develop lay leaders—the cadre—without first understanding the cultural soil in which these leaders are meant to be planted. If the formation curriculum is disconnected from the actual, lived values of the parish, the resulting leadership will be ineffective and misaligned.

To transition from abstract organizational blindness to empirical clarity, it is necessary to deploy established frameworks from organizational psychology, adapted specifically for the unique milieu of a religious institution. This requires a robust, multi-phased approach that combines theoretical culture models, specialized Catholic assessment instruments, qualitative discovery methodologies, rigorous data analysis, and strategic operationalization. The ensuing report outlines an exhaustive, step-by-step architecture for diagnosing, extracting, and living the core values of a Catholic parish.

Foundational Theoretical Frameworks of Organizational Culture

Before deploying specific assessment tools or conducting interviews, investigators must understand the structural models that categorize human behavior within institutions. Three foundational frameworks dominate the field of cultural assessment and provide the necessary theoretical scaffolding for a parish R&D initiative. Understanding these models prevents the team from merely collecting superficial data and forces a deeper investigation into the psychological underpinnings of the congregation.

Edgar Schein's Three-Tiered Model of Culture

Edgar Schein, a foundational pioneer in organizational studies, conceptualized culture as existing across three distinct layers of visibility and consciousness.[1] His insights into the psychological underpinnings of corporate behavior have greatly influenced theories about organizational development and change management.[1] Schein's model is particularly potent for religious organizations because it differentiates between what is publicly proclaimed from the pulpit and what is unconsciously practiced in the pews.[1]

Level of Culture	Conceptual Description	Practical Parish Context Example
Artifacts	The visible, tangible, and audible elements of the organization. These are easy to observe but often difficult to decipher regarding their deeper meaning.[1]	Architectural layout, liturgical music styles, the parish bulletin, demographic composition, financial reports, and even the office furniture.[2]
Espoused Values	The stated strategies, goals, and philosophies. These are the conscious, explicit principles the organization claims to prioritize.[1]	Mission statements, homilies, diocesan pastoral guidelines, and publicly stated core values printed on banners.[1]
Basic Underlying Assumptions	Unconscious, taken-for-granted beliefs, perceptions, and feelings. These are the ultimate sources of values and action.[1]	Unspoken beliefs about clerical authority, implicit racial or socioeconomic biases, and internalized definitions of salvation or community.[1]

For a parish R&D team, the objective is to penetrate beyond the Artifacts and Espoused Values to uncover the Basic Underlying Assumptions. Observational methods and deep qualitative

inquiries are required to reveal discrepancies between what the parish says it values and what it actually practices.[1] For example, a parish might espouse the value of "radical hospitality," yet an observation of its artifacts (e.g., lack of handicap accessibility, clique-driven seating arrangements) and underlying assumptions (e.g., prioritizing comfort over inclusion) reveals a contradictory culture. Consultants and leadership must examine all three levels to find weak spots and strengths, forming a targeted strategy for cultural alignment.[2] With cultural alignment, it is far easier to accomplish strategic goals, resulting in a much happier workspace for everyone involved.[2]

The Barrett Cultural Values Assessment (CVA) Model

The Barrett Cultural Values Assessment (CVA) provides a diagnostic foundation that maps the personal consciousness of organizational members against the collective consciousness of the institution.[3] This model is built upon Seven Levels of Consciousness, which categorize behaviors, values, and priorities, allowing organizations to form an idea of the organizational consciousness as the very essence of the entity.[3]

Level of Consciousness	Organizational Focus	Application in a Catholic Parish Setting
1. Viability	Financial stability and health.[4]	Parish funding, facility maintenance, and basic physical safety of the campus.[4]
2. Relationships	Interpersonal connections and trust.[4]	Pastoral care, fellowship events, and conflict resolution mechanisms among ministries.[4]
3. Performance	Achieving excellence and recognition.[4]	Efficacy of liturgical ministries, administration efficiency, and programmatic success.[4]
4. Evolution	Adaptability and continuous learning.[4]	Adult faith formation, adaptability to demographic shifts, and spiritual renewal programs.[4]

5. Alignment	Shared vision and values alignment.[4]	Cohesion between various parish ministries, the Cadre Formation team, and the central mission.[4]
6. Collaboration	Social responsibility and ethical practices.[4]	Community outreach, interfaith dialogue, and social justice initiatives within the neighborhood.[4]
7. Contribution	Selfless service and environmental sustainability.[4]	Long-term legacy planning, ecological stewardship, and deep spiritual communion.[4]

A critical output of the Barrett methodology is the measurement of "Cultural Entropy," which represents the amount of energy consumed in unproductive work due to potentially limiting values.[3] In a parish, high entropy manifests as bureaucracy, internal politics, turf wars between ministries, or fear of pastoral leadership.[4] By distributing values across these seven levels, researchers can find the balance of values and identify gaps between individual desires and current organizational realities.[3]

The structured implementation of the Barrett model involves five distinct steps. Step one is diagnosing the current culture by gathering input from employees and parishioners to map current values, desired values, and entropy levels.[4] Step two requires engaging leadership alignment, ensuring that the pastor and council members not only understand the desired culture but model it through their decisions, building trust and credibility.[4] Step three involves developing a clear plan with measurable objectives and specific timelines based on the diagnostic data.[4] Step four focuses on engaging employees and volunteers through clear communication regarding the "why" behind the change, utilizing workshops to reinforce behaviors.[4] Finally, step five emphasizes continuous monitoring and refining, using engagement and retention metrics to keep the transformation on track.[4]

The Competing Values Framework (CVF) and OCAI

The Competing Values Framework (CVF) and its associated assessment tool, the Organizational Culture Assessment Instrument (OCAI), offer a structured, quantitative approach to culture assessment that perfectly complements Schein's qualitative model.[1] Developed by Kim S. Cameron and Robert E. Quinn at the University of Michigan, the OCAI is a widely used instrument that evaluates the workplace or community across six domains: dominant characteristics, organizational leadership, employee management, organizational glue, strategic emphases, and criteria for success.[5]

Respondents are provided with four descriptions for each of the six domains and must allocate

100 points among them based on how accurately they represent the current environment.[5] This allows respondents to identify the organizational culture that best represents their workplace.[5] The results categorize the organization into one of four culture types: Clan (collaborative and family-like), Adhocracy (creative and dynamic), Market (competing and results-oriented), or Hierarchy (controlling and structured).[4] For an R&D team, deploying the OCAI allows for a multi-faceted view of the parish culture, providing statistical triangulation that can guide the Cadre Formation team in developing initiatives to build specific behaviors, such as prioritizing collaboration over hierarchy.[1]

Specialized Assessment Instruments for Catholic Parishes

While corporate models like the CVA and OCAI provide a structural foundation, faith-based organizations operate on specific theological premises that require tailored metrics. The Catholic Church has a distinct vernacular, canonical structure, and sacramental worldview. Consequently, several specialized instruments exist to assess the vitality, cultural engagement, and demographic realities of Catholic parishes.

The Disciple Maker Index (DMI)

The Disciple Maker Index (DMI) is a premier 95-question survey tool specifically engineered by the Catholic Leadership Institute to support Church ministry with objective data.[6] It helps leaders recognize their potential and envision future possibilities through a deep analysis of the congregation.[6] The survey is structured around four primary components, providing a comprehensive cultural snapshot of the parish.[6]

DMI Survey Domain	Focus of Inquiry	Sample Data or Question
Attitudes and Beliefs	Evaluates parishioners' understanding of core Catholic teachings and their personal, spiritual disposition toward the parish community.	"To what extent do you believe Jesus is truly present in the Eucharist?" [6]
Relationship and Satisfaction	Gathers feedback on the overall parish experience, the sense of hospitality within the community, and the effectiveness of the	"How likely are you to recommend your parish to a friend?" [6]

	pastor's leadership.	
Participation	Tracks the frequency with which parishioners engage in Catholic practices such as Mass attendance, reconciliation, and personal prayer.	Measurement of regular attendance, such as 91% of parishioners reporting going to Mass weekly.[6]
Demographics	Collects contextual data on age, gender, ethnicity, and tenure within the parish, which allows researchers to dive deeper into the data itself.	Filtering responses by demographic cohorts, such as identifying that 79% of parishioners are over the age of 35.[6]

The DMI enables researchers to establish robust benchmark groups, comparing local parish results with national trends, diocesan-wide data, and other parishes of a similar size or setting.[6] Furthermore, it identifies the "Top 3 Performers" and "Best Practices" in the country, allowing the R&D team to contextualize their localized data.[6] It is highly recommended that this survey be administered longitudinally—every two to three years—to track cultural shifts, measure progress, and evaluate the efficacy of strategic interventions implemented by the Cadre Formation team.[6] The interactive reporting software provided with the DMI allows leaders to compare any two survey questions to understand correlations and filter data by specific demographic groups.[6]

The Five-Step Framework for Parish Metrics

To effectively measure cultural vitality, parish leadership must transition from abstract guessing to rigorous metric tracking. The Catholic Leadership Institute outlines a comprehensive five-step process to bring appropriate metrics to parish ministry, aligning efforts toward the mission of the Church.[6]

Step one requires gathering hypotheses, narratives, and resources.[6] Before introducing a numerical framework, leaders should gather feedback from community members through focus groups hosted within existing organizations, such as the Knights of Columbus or Bible studies.[6] These groups listen to narratives about what makes the parish special and generate hypotheses regarding why people register, why they leave, and why the parish size has changed.[6] Step two mandates the creation of a shared framework of relevant metrics.[6] Whether the framework uses three or thirty metrics, the most critical factor is that the framework is universally understood and shared by as many people as possible, serving as a

collective guide.[6]

Step three emphasizes committing to the best tools, not necessarily the perfect tools.[6] Parishes should prioritize effective solutions, utilizing existing diocesan reports like the Status Animarum (State of the Souls) census alongside the DMI.[6] An iterative process involving a diverse ad-hoc team of 4-6 people should define the "What" (specific data), the "Why" (rationale), and the "How" (submission frequency).[6] Step four shifts the focus to actionable data.[6] Leaders must review the trends, analyze why the data shows these patterns, prioritize interventions relevant to the mission, dig deeper via qualitative testing, and capture specific action steps to resolve problems.[6] Finally, step five requires sharing the fruits of this labor proactively and creatively.[6] The R&D team should distribute an annual "state of the parish" summary, utilize meeting scorecards, present data visually via videos, and share the framework during new member orientations.[6]

Through these steps, parishes can gain profound insight into four key drivers of vibrancy: spiritual maturity, healthy organizational leadership, a vibrant Sunday experience, and a missionary impulse.[6]

Alternative and Complementary Parish Assessment Tools

In addition to the DMI, other specialized rubrics can be adapted by the R&D team to assess specific cultural vectors. The Thriving Parish Assessment utilizes 16 characteristics of parish vitality, drawn from ecclesial vision and sociological studies, to measure organizational thriving on scales of importance and implementation.[7]

Furthermore, comprehensive evangelization assessments measure cultural parameters focused on outward missionary impulses.[8] These tools evaluate the cultivation of active ministries, the design of outreach programs for those who have ceased being active in the Church, the integration of cultural diversity, and the depth of ecumenical involvement.[8] They ask whether the parish effectively invites people through mailings, home visits, or neighborhood publicity, and whether the parish fosters environments like RCIA or Alpha to welcome newcomers.[8]

Other diagnostic rubrics, such as the Parish Assessment Tool designed by Marcel LeJeune, measure reality against vision on a four-point Likert scale (from "None" to "Very Effective").[9] This tool asks if the parish mission is concrete, concise, compelling, and communicated, and critically, whether budgeting, staffing, and calendaring accurately reflect those espoused values.[9] It forces leadership to confront whether all programming is at the service of the mission, and if not, whether it has been discontinued.[9] Furthermore, macro-level academic frameworks, such as the Notre Dame Study of Catholic Parish Life, stress the importance of operationally defining what constitutes a "parishioner" in the research design—differentiating between canonical Catholics (baptized/confirmed), regular communicants, and cultural

Catholics who lack connection to the Sacraments but still identify with the community.[10]

Qualitative Discovery Methodologies: Uncovering the "Why"

Quantitative surveys like the OCAI and DMI provide the "what" of an organization's culture. They can identify that 80% of the parish feels disconnected, or that the culture is highly hierarchical. However, uncovering the "why" and the "how"—the basic underlying assumptions in Schein's model—requires rigorous qualitative methodologies.[1] Qualitative analysis reveals deeper insights beyond numbers, capturing the emotions, motivations, and experiences of the congregation.[11]

The Appreciative Inquiry Paradigm

Traditional organizational development often relies on a deficit model, assuming the role of leaders is to find the problems and fix them.[12] When a parish faces declining membership, a changing neighborhood, or a dearth of young families, the instinct is to focus exclusively on inadequacies.[12] However, when this problem-solving approach dominates, the interpretive grid becomes entirely negative.[12]

Appreciative Inquiry (AI) represents a radical paradigm shift in cultural discovery. Originating in the early 1980s when David Cooperrider was hired to conduct an organizational diagnosis of the Cleveland Clinic, AI posits that all organizations possess significant life forces and positive core attributes.[12] Instead of asking what is broken, AI intentionally focuses on the data of moments of joy, wonder, and excellence to ignite transformative dialogue.[13] A foundational study at the University of Wisconsin demonstrated the power of the positive question: when comparing two bowling teams analyzing their performance videos, the team that studied its successes improved significantly more than the team that studied its mistakes.[13]

For a parish R&D team, AI is not merely a strategic planning method; it is a way of seeing and creating, forming an interpretive community that perceives the best elements of its past to construct hopeful images of the future.[12]

Appreciative Interviewing and Focus Group Protocols

To deploy Appreciative Inquiry effectively, researchers must utilize customized interview guides designed to generate rich, qualitative narratives from the congregation.[13] Focus groups should be segmented to ensure psychological safety, separating clergy from lay staff, and parish council members from ordinary parishioners. This segmentation helps reduce measurement bias, such as peer pressure on focus group participants when speaking in front of authority figures.[15]

The questioning protocols are specifically designed to elicit deep cultural artifacts, values, and

underlying assumptions. The interview protocols can be structured into three core areas of focus:

Focusing on the Congregation:

- "What are the most important contributions the church has made to your life? When did this happen, and who made a difference?" [16]
- "What are the most valuable ways you contribute to this church—in terms of personality, perspective, skills, and gifts?" [16]
- "When have you grown as a follower of Jesus within this church? How did this happen?" [16]
- "What is it that makes this church unique? How do you see God's presence making itself known in your present reality?" [16]

Focusing on Collaboration and Organizational Efficacy:

- "Tell me about a time when you were forced to do more with less, and the results exceeded your wildest expectations. Who was involved, and how were the results achieved?" [17]
- "When you think of a time when you collaborated with another group within the parish and did so successfully, what comes to mind? What circumstances allowed the collaboration to occur?" [17]
- "Think about a time when you felt incredibly well supported by someone or a group of people from another ministry. Tell me about that time." [17]

Focusing on the External Community:

- "How might you describe or define the community in which God has placed your church? What do you love about the community around your church?" [16]
- "Beyond the work of your church, what kingdom work do you see being addressed in this community? What kingdom work still needs attention?" [16]

These protocols can be further adapted to reflect theological mandates, such as the Great Commandment, exploring how the congregation demonstrates love for God, neighbor, and self.[14] By synthesizing the narratives generated from these positive inquiries, the R&D team can extract the actual, lived values of the congregation.

Mixed-Methods Triangulation in Research Design

To ensure the absolute validity of the cultural assessment, researchers must employ methodological triangulation.[18] Triangulation involves collecting data from multiple sources (individuals, groups, or organizational structures) using different methodologies to cross-verify findings, integrate them, and eliminate bias.[18]

In organizational culture research, sampling bias—where the data only represents a vocal minority—and measurement bias—where the method of collection influences the

response—are significant risks.[15] Triangulating anonymous quantitative surveys (like the DMI) with qualitative focus groups effectively mitigates these risks.[15] A mixed-methods approach is crucial for addressing the common problem of small sample sizes and achieving a multidimensional understanding of the organization.[20]

The sequencing of triangulation can follow either an exploratory or explanatory design based on the needs of the R&D team. Researchers may first conduct exploratory focus groups and one-on-one interviews to learn about the parish's unique vernacular, historical context, and cultural pain points, using those qualitative findings to design or customize a quantitative survey.[21] Conversely, they may deploy a standardized survey first to capture broad statistical trends, and then utilize targeted focus groups to explain and contextualize anomalies or strong data points found in the numerical data.[20]

Participatory Frameworks for Values Discovery

Beyond interviews and broad surveys, discovering core values requires participatory exercises that engage the Cadre Formation team, the parish council, and the broader congregation directly. These exercises force participants to distill broad philosophical concepts into actionable behaviors and prioritize what truly matters.

Do-It-Yourself (DIY) Discovery Workshops

For organizations seeking to facilitate internal discovery without relying exclusively on expensive external consultants, structured workshop formats yield exceptionally high-quality qualitative data.[22] These workshops are designed to foster dialogue, reveal misalignments, and build consensus around shared principles.[24] Even if organizing a massive group session isn't feasible, the R&D team can conduct these steps within smaller councils and aggregate the insights.[24]

A foundational exercise to kick-start thinking asks the assembled group to answer a single guiding question in narrative form: *"What does it look like when we are doing our best work?"*.[22] Participants are instructed to write their response in a paragraph or two. The facilitator then extracts recurring keywords and behavioral descriptors from these narratives, mapping them onto a physical or virtual whiteboard.[22] This exercise is brilliant because it grounds the discovery of values in actual historical precedents and lived experiences rather than aspirational, theoretical jargon.

A subsequent phase utilizes a structured prioritization worksheet designed for non-profits.[23] The workshop follows a specific cadence:

1. **Reflect and Brainstorm:** Individually or in small groups, participants brainstorm words that reflect the organization's current values.[23]
2. **Prioritize:** The group reviews the brainstormed list and narrows it down to the absolute

top 5–7 core values.[23]

3. **Define and Apply:** The team must then explicitly define what each value means in their specific context and outline exactly how the organization lives this value.[23]
4. **Accountability Prompts:** The workshop concludes with critical discussion prompts: *How do these values influence our decision-making? Are there gaps between what we say and what we do? Where should these values be visible (e.g., website, hiring practices, partnerships)? How do we hold ourselves accountable to living these values?*.[23]

The Values Card Sort Methodology

A highly tactile and effective methodology for uncovering personal and organizational priorities is the Values Card Sort. This exercise requires participants to evaluate a comprehensive list of values and rank them according to their current importance, forcing difficult decisions about what is truly essential.[25]

The mechanics of the exercise involve providing participants with a deck of cards, each containing a single value and a brief definition.[26] The sorting protocol follows strict parameters. First, participants receive the deck alongside three category anchor cards: "Most Important To Me Right Now," "Important To Me Right Now," and "Less Important To Me Right Now" (or "Not Important").[26] Blank cards are provided to allow participants to write in missing values that are highly specific to their localized culture.[26] Second, participants have a limited time—typically around 3 minutes—to rapidly sort all cards into the three columns, relying on instinct.[25] Third, participants are instructed to review their "Most Important" column and ruthlessly narrow it down to their top five values, rank-ordering them from one to five.[25] Finally, individual results are recorded, and the facilitator aggregates the data using event codes to determine the collective priorities of the room, comparing individual responses against the group average.[28]

This methodology can be customized to differentiate between *Core Values* (the essential characteristics of the community, such as integrity or obedience to God) and *Ministry Values* (the operational principles governing action, such as "people over programs" or "evangelism over perfection").[29]

To facilitate this exercise, the R&D team can utilize the following comprehensive taxonomy of standard values, synthesized from psychological and organizational research models.[27]

Value Category	**Specific Value**	**Operational Definition**
Interpersonal & Relational	**Acceptance**	To be accepted as I am.

	Caring	To take care of others.
	Compassion	To feel and act on concern for others.
	Cooperation	To work collaboratively with others.
	Courtesy	To be considerate and polite toward others.
	Forgiveness	To be forgiving of others.
	Friendship	To have close, supportive friends.
	Loved	To be loved by those close to me.
	Respect	To treat others considerately and tolerate differences.
Integrity & Character	**Authenticity/Genuineness**	To act in a manner that is genuine and being myself.
	Commitment	To make enduring, meaningful commitments.

	Dependability/Trust	To be reliable, loyal, sincere, and trustworthy.
	Honesty/Integrity	To live daily life consistent with my values.
	Humility	To be modest and unassuming.
	Responsibility	To make and carry out responsible decisions.
	Virtue	To live a morally pure and honorable life.
Achievement & Growth	**Achievement**	To have important accomplishments.
	Challenge	To take on difficult tasks and problems.
	Creativity/Imagination	To have new and original ideas and see possibilities.
	Industry/Hard Work	To work hard and well at my life tasks.
	Intelligence	To keep my mind sharp and

		active.
	Persistence	To continue resolutely despite difficulties.
Autonomy & Leadership	**Authority/Power**	To be in charge of, influence, or wield authority over others.
	Autonomy/Independence	To be self-determined and free from depending on others.
	Leadership	To inspire and guide others.
Spiritual & Existential	**Inner Peace**	To experience personal peace.
	Purpose	To have meaning and direction in my life.
	Spirituality	To grow and mature in the understanding of higher power(s).
Societal & Environmental	**Contribution**	To make a lasting contribution in the world.
	Ecology	To live in harmony with the environment.

	Justice	To promote fair and equal treatment for all.
	Patriotism	To love, serve, and protect my country.
Lifestyle & Wellbeing	**Adventure/Excitement**	To have new, exciting experiences full of thrills.
	Balance	To be intentional about balance in life.
	Comfort/Pleasure	To have a pleasant, comfortable life and feel good.
	Family	To have a happy, loving family and provide for them.
	Fitness/Health	To be physically fit and take care of myself.
	Wealth	To accumulate and possess financial prosperity.

By actively engaging with this taxonomy, the Cadre Formation team can identify exactly which values resonate most deeply with the core leadership of the parish, providing a statistical baseline for cultural definition.

Qualitative Data Analysis: Thematic Coding for

Cultural Values

Once the Appreciative Inquiry interviews, focus groups, and discovery workshops are completed, the R&D team will possess a massive corpus of unstructured qualitative data, including transcripts, field notes, observation memos, and open-ended survey responses.[11] Unlike numerical data housed in Excel or Power BI, qualitative information provides deep context regarding human motivations, but it requires rigorous systematization to yield usable intelligence.[11]

The industry standard methodology for translating raw text into structured cultural architecture is Thematic Analysis, specifically utilizing the rigorous six-phase framework developed by Braun and Clarke.[33] The qualitative analysis process aims to identify themes and patterns that emerge across the data, organizing it into meaningful knowledge.[32]

The Six Phases of Thematic Analysis

Phase	Procedural Execution	Methodological Goal
1. Familiarization	Immersion in the dataset. Researchers begin by reading transcripts repeatedly, listening to audio recordings, and taking preliminary notes on initial ideas and patterns.[33]	To establish a comprehensive cognitive map of the entire data corpus before deconstruction begins.[33]
2. Generating Initial Codes	Systematic labeling. Researchers assign short, descriptive codes to specific sentences or paragraphs that capture key concepts, actions, or features observed in the text.[33]	To dismantle unstructured text into discrete, indexable data points that can be referenced quickly.[33]
3. Generating Themes	Collating the initial codes into broader, overarching conceptual categories. Researchers group related excerpts, finding logical patterns that connect	To elevate granular data into macro-level cultural concepts representing shared values or assumptions.[33]

	codes together.[33]	
4. Reviewing Themes	Iterative refinement. Researchers test the proposed themes against the original coded extracts and the entire dataset to ensure they accurately represent the data without forcing a narrative.[34]	To ensure themes are well-supported, distinct from one another, and directly answer the core research questions, merging or eliminating them as needed.[33]
5. Defining and Naming	Drafting strict operational definitions for each theme. The names must be punchy, descriptive, and immediately understandable to organizational leadership.[34]	To finalize the vocabulary that will become the newly articulated organizational culture.[35]
6. Writing Up	Producing a final, coherent analytical report. The narrative must tie the themes back to the strategic objectives, supported by vivid, anonymized quotes from the data.[33]	To translate analytical findings into actionable recommendations, demonstrating the broader significance of the findings.[33]

In contemporary R&D environments, this rigorous coding process can be augmented by qualitative data analysis software. Programs like ATLAS.ti assist in organizing transcripts, linking codes, and visualizing data relationships.[32] Furthermore, AI-powered platforms like Thematic can automatically code open-ended feedback into themes, making the process faster and easier without manual setup.[11] However, for assessing deep cultural phenomena—particularly the theological and interpersonal nuances of a Catholic parish—human oversight is paramount. Generative AI excels at organizing the data, but researchers must seek automation with human oversight to accurately interpret the nuances of religious vernacular.[11]

The output of the thematic analysis provides the empirical justification for the final list of core organizational values. When the R&D team presents the cultural framework to the Cadre Formation team and the parish council, they can defend the chosen values not as arbitrary selections, but as scientifically coded derivatives of the congregation's own lived experience.

Operationalizing Values into Strategic Behaviors

A primary failure in cultural management occurs when values remain lofty, ambiguous concepts. Values that are not explicitly tethered to specific, observable behaviors become cynical corporate platitudes. As research indicates, a courageous culture connects its values to specific behaviors so people know exactly what is expected, encouraged, and rewarded within their team and organization.[36] Living into values requires moving from lofty ideals to operationalized practices; otherwise, it is better not to profess any values at all.[36]

Operationalizing values means establishing shared language and clear behavioral standards.[36] If a parish selects "Reverence" as a core value derived from the thematic analysis, the Cadre Formation team must translate that into measurable action items. Does reverence dictate the dress code of the staff? Does it define the liturgical posture of the congregation? Does it influence how conflict is mediated in council meetings? This process gives organizations well-defined cultural standards that help determine fit during volunteer recruitment and offer straightforward metrics when non-performance-related issues arise.[36]

This operationalization feeds directly into the parish's Strategic Plan. A strategic plan outlines the future direction of the organization, identifying how resources will be allocated to achieve a desired future state.[37] The extracted cultural values must become the foundation of this plan.

According to strategic planning rubrics, each *Strategic Priority* represents the organization's focused commitment to pursuing its mission and values.[37] These priorities are conceptual targets supported by *Defining Objectives*, which are the overarching goals through which each priority will be addressed.[37] Crucially, values are brought to life through *Action Items*—the specific steps required to execute the objectives.[37] Each action item must be tied to a specific timeline and a *Responsible Party* (a person or organizational role responsible for execution), and evaluated by *Measures of Success* or Key Performance Indicators (KPIs) representing a quantifiable measure of performance.[37] By mapping the discovered cultural values directly to strategic action items, the culture becomes embedded in the operational machinery of the parish.

Contextual Application: Integrating Local Pastoral Guidelines

An organizational culture assessment within a Catholic parish does not occur in a vacuum; it is situated within the broader hierarchical structure and theological vision of the local diocese. Any values discovered by the R&D team must ultimately harmonize with the strategic orientation of the presiding Bishop or Archbishop. If the parish identifies values that fundamentally contradict the diocesan mandate, the culture will experience high entropy and systemic friction.

To demonstrate how localized cultural research intersects with macro-ecclesial strategy, it is highly instructive to examine the *Arah Dasar* (Basic Direction or ArDas) of the Keuskupan Agung Jakarta (Archdiocese of Jakarta - KAJ), which serves as a prime example of institutional cultural mapping.

Analyzing the Macro-Strategy: ArDas KAJ 2022-2026

The strategic direction for the Archdiocese of Jakarta spanning 2022 to 2026 is encapsulated in three core cultural imperatives: *Mengasihi, Peduli, dan Bersaksi* (Loving, Caring, and Witnessing).[38] The theological and sociological underpinnings of this strategy are profoundly focused on the restoration of human dignity and ecological stewardship, responding to a post-truth era where human reliance on divine providence has waned, likened to the archetype of Cain who lost care for his fellow man.[38]

The implementation of this diocesan culture relies heavily on symbolism and actionable spiritualities. The official iconography of the 2022-2026 ArDas depicts open hands facing upward—symbolizing the restoration of humanity by God—and hands facing downward—symbolizing the human mandate to actively care and witness to the surrounding community.[38] Another symbol utilized is a sailboat with unfurled sails, representing the Church navigating forward optimistically to aid the weak and poor.[41] Furthermore, these strategic goals are explicitly operationalized into specific spiritualities of action: providing clothing to the naked, drink to the thirsty, shelter to the homeless, and food to the hungry.[41]

Historical analysis of the Archdiocese indicates that transitions between strategic periods (such as from the 2011-2015 to the 2016-2020 and current ArDas) rely heavily on research, data collection, and the progressive transformation of parish organizational structures.[42] The diocese explicitly views the laity as the primary operators of the Church's mission, repositioning clergy and activists as servant-leaders facilitating the building of the Kingdom of God.[44]

Socio-Spiritual Accountability and Entrepreneurial Leadership

A localized parish R&D team analyzing its internal culture must filter its findings through these macro-directives. For instance, academic research regarding institutional behavior within the Jakarta Archdiocese highlights the critical concept of "Socio-Spiritual Accountability".[45] Unlike secular corporations where accountability is purely financial and material, socio-spiritual accountability incorporates religious teachings—specifically love, humanity, and justice—into the management of resources and community entities like parish cooperatives.[45]

This accountability manifests in highly observable cultural artifacts: the sincere and generous service of governing boards, high levels of solidarity among members, and the execution of duties with fidelity and honesty.[45] Furthermore, adapting to these comprehensive cultural demands requires an evolution in pastoral leadership. Evidence from the Archdiocese of Jakarta indicates that the role of parish priests has fundamentally expanded beyond being

primarily religious figures.[46] Priests must now exhibit behaviors akin to "entrepreneurial leadership".[46] They are required to manage complex non-profit organizational ecosystems, navigating internal dynamics and external community challenges while driving toward non-financial, spiritual growth.[46] This mirrors entrepreneurial leadership in for-profit organizations, but without the material expectations.[46]

When a parish R&D unit conducts its thematic analysis and values coding, it must intentionally look for the presence—or absence—of these diocesan imperatives. If the parish discovers through its card sort exercises and focus groups that "Tradition," "Comfort," and "Inward Friendship" are its primary lived values, but the diocesan ArDas demands "Caring," "Witnessing," and "Socio-Spiritual Innovation," the R&D team has diagnosed a critical gap in cultural alignment.

This gap analysis becomes the central, actionable agenda for the Cadre Formation team. It dictates the specific curriculum, retreats, and training required to align the parish culture with the broader mission of the local Church, moving the congregation from its current state of comfort into a state of active, outward-facing discipleship.

Conclusion

The pursuit of discovering, codifying, and operationalizing the cultural values of a Catholic parish is a complex, multidisciplinary endeavor requiring rigorous adherence to organizational psychology protocols. By moving past superficial artifacts and examining the basic underlying assumptions of the congregation, a parish R&D unit can accurately diagnose the true health and trajectory of the community.

Success necessitates a highly structured, phased architecture. The process must be grounded in robust theoretical frameworks like Edgar Schein's model of culture, the Barrett Cultural Values Assessment, and the Competing Values Framework. It requires the deployment of specialized, faith-based metrics like the Disciple Maker Index to gather quantitative data. To uncover the qualitative "why" behind the numbers, the team must deploy the asset-based paradigm of Appreciative Inquiry, conducting deep focus groups that study organizational successes rather than just deficits.

Furthermore, the discovery process must be participatory, utilizing Do-It-Yourself discovery workshops and tactile exercises such as the Values Card Sort to force the leadership to prioritize essential behaviors. The massive amount of qualitative data generated must then be rigorously coded through the six phases of Thematic Analysis to ensure the final values are empirically justified rather than arbitrarily chosen. Finally, this quantitative and qualitative triangulation must be contextualized within the strategic pastoral directives of the local diocese, operationalizing the resulting values into measurable strategic action items.

By executing this exhaustive methodology, the parish transitions from a state of operational

blindness to profound strategic clarity. The resulting cultural framework ensures that the values guiding the parish are not hollow corporate catchphrases, but empirically derived, deeply authentic behaviors. Armed with this knowledge, the Cadre Formation team can effectively fulfill its mandate, shaping a vibrant, aligned, and spiritually resilient leadership cadre capable of navigating the complex socio-spiritual challenges of the modern era.

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